

Incident Alert: 0033. TLP: CLEAR.			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	RO	Suspicious TikTok Accounts Boosting Romanian Presidential Candidate	28/11/2024	2

Summary

- Romanian presidential candidate Calin Georgescu appears to be receiving large amounts of support on TikTok via inauthentic means.
- 66 accounts identified on TikTok appear to be in violation the platform's rules on impersonation and/or show signs of coordinated inauthentic behaviour or the use of fake engagements.
- Several prominent pro-Georgescu accounts appeared overnight with follower counts in the tens of thousands.
- 41 out of the 47 accounts flagged were taken down by TikTok.

Incident

On 27 November 2024, DRI identified a total of 66 accounts on TikTok that potentially violate the platform's rules on impersonation and/or show signs of coordinated inauthentic behaviour or the use of fake engagements. At least 22 of these accounts were created between 27 and 28 November 2024.

The identified accounts are not verified as representative of a political candidate, nor do they provide information about what type of account they represent, but they nonetheless use Mr. Georgescu's image or campaign logo. TikTok's policy notes that "parody or fan-based accounts must be clearly disclosed in the account name.

By 28 November, before the publication of this brief, DRI reviewed the accounts again and found that TikTok had already removed 19 of them, likely for impersonation violations.

More importantly, **a significant number of these accounts remain active**. While some may not violate TikTok's impersonation rules—partly due to the platform's lax policies that allow users to bypass its impersonation policy by simply adding the word "fan" to their account names—they may still be in violation of the platform's policies on fake engagements and coordinated inauthentic behavior.

Narrative

Meta narratives: Vote for Calin Georgescu

Impact

Mr. Georgescu's account gained 288.8k followers within the last 30 days. Several pro-Georgescu accounts received thousands of followers within an extremely short period of time. These accounts circumvent TikTok's restriction on the algorithmic promotion of politicians and party accounts by not being declared as part of the Georgescu campaign.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

- Objective: [Cultivate Support for Ally](#) - Promote Romanian far-right presidential candidate Calin Georgescu.
- [Impersonated Persona](#) – The TikTok accounts are impersonating Mr. Georgescu, spreading his messaging.
- [Manipulate Platform Algorithm](#) – The accounts are seemingly using fake engagement to amplify their reach.
- [Conceal Network Identity](#) – The accounts are not revealing their affiliations, at times posing as fan accounts.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

- Action taken: DRI has informed the European Commission and TikTok.
- Result 41 out of 47 accounts where taken down by TikTok after .
- TikTok should: remove all accounts in Romania (and beyond) that violate its guidelines; Modify its policies and community guidelines to increase transparency and integrity of the platform. They should be at least at the level of other social media platforms; Conduct a thorough investigation into the platform's role in the Romanian presidential elections and make the findings publicly available.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Elections	See Report	Michael Meyer-Resende. Daniela Alvarado Rincon, DRI	Video	TikTok